

SMILING FOR THE CAMERA: THE INFLUENCE OF FILM AUDIENCES ON A BUDGET TOURISM DESTINATION

SUE BEETON

School of Tourism & Hospitality, La Trobe University, Australia

Today's focus on attracting the "high yield" tourist to established destinations has the potential to dramatically alter the mix of visitors to an area, alienating the existing tourism market. In many areas the budget, family holiday-maker is being edged out by the push to attract higher spending socioeconomic groups. A case study approach has been adopted to consider the impacts of such change precipitated by the little-understood phenomenon of film-induced tourism. The seaside village of Barwon Heads is experiencing change through the success of the ABC TV series, *Sea Change*. Viewers of *Sea Change* consist of the main ABC viewer demographic of educated, professionally employed Australians in the range of 40–65 years of age. Film-induced tourism to the area is altering the mix of visitors, which in turn may impact on the traditional holiday market, not merely through increased demand, but also by creating a new, intrusive style of tourism that directly affects the traditional holiday-maker. Issues that affect the traditional holiday-maker include a loss of privacy, especially in terms of those staying in the local caravan park, an increase in holiday rental prices, and a growing sense of inadequacy in relation to the increase in the highly visual, high-yield visitor. The outcomes of this study have applicability to other rural communities contemplating moves into new tourist markets, as well as those whose councils may wish to encourage the filming of television programs and movies as an economic fillip.

Film-induced tourism	Community	High yield
----------------------	-----------	------------

The Victorian state tourism body, Tourism Victoria, released its initial Strategic Business Plan in 1993, setting out its objectives for the next 3 years (Tourism Victoria, 1993). A key objective was to position the state as a significant tourism destination, appointing a range of consultants to undertake the development of Regional Tourism Development Plans for the 13 regions of the state. The reports were

released throughout 1997/1998 in conjunction with Tourism Victoria's second business plan for 1997–2001. The business plan clearly directs regional tourism bodies to target high-yield market segments, which is reinforced by the main strategies in each of the regional tourism plans.

Tourism Victoria utilized the Roy Morgan Value Segments to identify the high-yielding tourist seg-

ments, which constitute 53% of the population but do not include traditional family budget holiday-makers (termed as the "Basic Needs," "Real Conservatism," "Conventional Family Life," and "Fairer Deal" value segments) who make up a further 25% of the population and 22% of the local budget holiday market (Tourism Victoria, 1997). As such, not only is a significant tourist group ignored, but also discouraged through the priorities in the proposed strategies.

Analysis of the regional tourism plans provides a similar scenario. Each of the 13 plans refers to the need to attract the high-yield markets, ignoring the majority of the budget market. For example, the Regional Tourism Development Plan for the Bays and Peninsula region (which includes the focus area of this article) identifies the same high-yielding value segments as Tourism Victoria in both their primary and secondary markets, ignoring a large segment of the budget holiday market (KPMG, 1997). This is repeated in all the regional plans.

While it may be sensible to focus on high-yielding tourist segments (which will not always be lucrative if the actual numbers are not there), it must be recognized that other segments also take holidays, particularly to regional and coastal centers. What we are now witnessing is the squeezing out of the budget holiday-maker in the rush for the limited high-yield tourist, which in turn impacts socially and culturally on our community and may result in further disenfranchisement of the lower socioeconomic groups.

Such changes to the tourist mix can also be precipitated (and compounded) by external factors that may not be foreseen, planned, or controlled by tourism per se. An example of this is in the use of an area or town in a film or television series, where the location scout and producers are not cognizant of the potential social impacts their activities may produce. For example, hoteliers in Goathland (the town portrayed as Aidensfield in the TV series *Heartbeat*) found they had lower occupancy levels after the success of the series, even though the town of 200 residents experiences upwards of 1.1 million annual visitors (Demetriadi, 1996). The town had previously attracted a "low-yield" market looking for the peace and quiet of a small country town, staying in small guesthouses and bed and breakfasts. However, due to the massive increase in visitor numbers, the town

has been repositioned as a day visitor attraction, with the traditional holiday-makers forced to move on to quieter areas (Demetriadi, 1996).

This article considers how an external factor such as film can initiate change in the traditional nature of a tourist community and questions the validity and equitability of focusing on high-yield visitors at a traditionally budget holiday destination.

Literature Review

While figures relating directly to the impact that films (both movies and television series) have had on tourism are limited, there are still some impressive data. In 1978, the year after *Close Encounters of the Third Kind* was released, visitation to Devil's Tower National Monument increased by a staggering 74%, while in a survey conducted 11 years after the film's premier, one-fifth of respondents attributed their initial knowledge of the monument to the movie (Tooke & Baker, 1996).

Numerous tourism boards developed tourist precincts based on literary figures (such as Burns Country), and this has been extended to incorporate themed products based on film and television. There are a number of examples from the United Kingdom, including, "East Ender Breaks," "Last of the Summer Wine Country," "Coronation Street Experience," and "In the Footsteps of Brother Cadfael," with fiction being incorporated into historic sites and events (Schofield, 1996). Where fiction is being combined with fact, boundaries can become blurred between what is real and unreal. However, tourists are often more interested in experiencing what has been promoted through the powerful visual media than gazing at so-called "dead" history. This certainly raises issues of authenticity, perception, and tourist wants/needs, and will be dealt with in a further paper.

The Australian Case

Between 1981 and 1988 United States tourists to Australia increased by 20.5% per annum (Tooke & Baker, 1996). This massive increase has been attributed to a number of factors, not the least being the impact of Australian movies such as *Mad Max* (released in the US in 1980), *The Man from Snowy River* (1982), and *Crocodile Dundee* (1986). According to O'Regan (1988), in 1987 international tourism

rose faster in Australia than in any other developed nation, admittedly from a modest base.

A new tourism industry has grown on the back of the two *Man from Snowy River* movies, particularly in the Mansfield district where the movie was filmed (even though the story was actually set in country further north-east, where the Snowy River really flows), from horseback tours through to restaurants such as the Snowy River Steakhouse, and canvas and saddlery suppliers such as the Snowy Mountain Rug Company (Beeton, 1998). Horseback tourism in Australia's High Country has increased 10-fold, growing from 3 operators before the movie's release to over 30 in 1996 (Department of Natural Resources and Environment, 1996). The Hunt Club Hotel in Merrijig, where most of the cast and crew stayed and/or socialized, has decorated its walls with photographs and memorabilia from the movie, and locals still dine out on stories of the stars.

It must be noted, however, that during the 1980s, there was a range of other high-profile international events that took place, including the America's Cup Defence (1986–1987), Australian Grand Prix (1985 onwards), and Australia's Bicentenary and World Expo (1988), as well as the falling Australian dollar that made travel from the US even more attractive and affordable.

The Benefits and Drawbacks of Film-Induced Tourism

A range of benefits has been identified by the researchers looking at this phenomenon; however, they do not appear to have been adequately quantified, most likely due to the limited work done in this area to date. Schofield (1996) commented that due to their association with fame, buildings and streets that were formerly considered commonplace and ordinary suddenly acquire interest, status, and ambience. This could also be said for some aspects of the natural environment and people. Riley, Baker, and Van Doren (1998) identified the following tourism benefits flowing on from filming:

- introduction of organized tours,
- expansion of community festivals,
- different use of sites, for example for corporate team-building,
- memorabilia sales,

- hotels and guest houses that were used as film locations.

One of the major economic benefits and factors of film-induced tourism is that viewing past locations can be an all-year, all-weather attraction, thus spreading out the inevitable seasonality inherent in so many tourist attractions. Also, both movies and television have a wide socioeconomic appeal, potentially broadening the base of the visitor market (Schofield, 1996). According to the Executive Director of the Madison County Chamber of Commerce, Doug Hawley, the tourism generated from the movie, *Bridges of Madison County*, kept the region alive, creating an international market for their covered bridges (Edington, 1996). The Scottish Tourism Board (STB) recognized the promotional benefits of such Hollywood movies as *Rob Roy* and *Braveheart*, working hard to capitalize on the images that were being presented to the world. Derek Reid, the Chief Executive of the STB, persuaded MGM to run, free of charge, a Scottish travel advertisement before each screening of *Rob Roy* in the US ("Rob Roy to the Rescue," 1995). This also provided them with the opportunity to diversify their market beyond their mainstay English visitors.

Bringing new business people into the tourism industry, and encouraging them to take it seriously is a major challenge facing the industry worldwide, and film-induced tourism provide some opportunities in this area by introducing other members of the business community to the flow-on benefits of film-induced tourism. Tom Kershaw, the owner of the Bull and Finch hotel in Boston, has become extremely active in both the local and national tourism industry ever since the façade of his hotel was used as the site of the bar in the long running series *Cheers*, to the extent that in 1994 he was appointed by President Clinton to the US Travel and Tourism Administration's advisory board (Neale, 1994). The direct economic benefits of *Cheers* that Kershaw has realized include around 500,000 visitors to his pub per annum, an annual food and beverage turnover of US\$6m, and *Cheers* merchandising sales of around US\$7m (Neale, 1994).

As always, however, there is a range of potentially negative attributes or drawbacks of film-induced tourism, which are mainly in the less-quantifiable areas of social and environmental impacts.

Tooke and Baker (1996) consider the (usually limited) carrying capacity of a site to be a major concern for an area that gains sudden tourist significance, particularly in relation to increased vehicle traffic and pedestrian congestion. Riley et al. (1998) have identified the drawbacks of main concern as:

- exploitation of locals,
- driving up local prices,
- exploitation of visitors,
- lack of preparedness from locals when dealing with the tourist influx,
- location appears different to how it is portrayed on film, resulting in a loss of visitor satisfaction,
- imitators,
- souvenir hunters, especially those that seek highway and street signs.

The first three relate to any increased tourist visitation regardless of the reason, whereas the remainder can be seen as specifically related to film-induced tourism.

A poignant example of the drawbacks of film-induced tourism can be found in Juffure, the African village on which Alex Haley based his book and mini-series, *Roots*. Tourists are visiting the town, and Gambia's tourist trade is now its number two industry after agriculture, largely due to the success of *Roots*. However, the villagers are disillusioned, poor, and resentful of the promises of a future that did not eventuate. They feel that Haley and others made fortunes out of them, but that they received too little in return, both financially and socially, resulting in resentment towards tourists and the *Roots* phenomenon ("African Village Says," 1995).

After the success of the TV series, *Pride and Prejudice*, the Friends of the Lake District expressed concern over what they termed the "Darcy Effect," which included negative social and environmental impacts. They were concerned that money would have to be diverted from other community projects to repair wear and tear and provide additional infrastructure and services for tourists, which is more than mere "opportunity cost" (Friends of the Lake District, 1996). However, they failed to recognize any additional benefits that increased tourist numbers would bring, indicating a lack of community consultation and education in this area, which is not

surprising when one considers who would be responsible for such consultation—the film-makers who will be long gone by the time the impacts become evident, or the tourist association who most likely had little to do with the filming or choice of location. Local councils, who, at the very least, have to approve certain aspects of the filming such as closing public areas, need to take a more proactive role here. The Friends of the Lake District (1996) suggest, somewhat naively, that the producers and film companies consider the effects and costs to the community of the success of their projects. A further example of the immediate problems that film production can bring can be seen in Thailand, where 20th Century Fox recently made a movie called *The Beach*. It appears that the beach being used for the film has been bulldozed, widened, and much of the native vegetation removed. Such is the concern about the destruction of the natural environment that North Americans are being asked to boycott the film, sign a petition, or write to the producer, by conservationists such as Prof. Paul Eagles, the Chair of the Task Force on Tourism and Protected Areas, World Conservation Union (Bushell, 1999).

An important, potentially ambiguous aspect to be considered when attempting to maximize the benefits of film-induced tourism is that of the actual versus imagined (as created by the film). Butler (1980) points out that films are often not shot at the locations they purport to be. For example, the Philippines was used to depict Vietnam in *Platoon*, and Canada is often used for the United States, as in the case of the sequel to the *Blues Brothers* ("Lures and Enticements," 1998). This can create a situation where people are basing their knowledge on false information as well as developing false expectations of sites they choose to visit, resulting in dissatisfaction with the experience. This notion is confirmed by Hall (1995) as the appeal of tourist attractions relates directly to the image that the tourists have brought with them.

An interesting phenomenon has been noted at some tourist sites that have been featured in film, which is a negative shift in certain types of visitation. As already discussed, Demetriadi (1996) found that hoteliers and guesthouse proprietors in Goathland were experiencing lower occupancy levels after the success of the series, *Heartbeat*. He conjectures that the town has been repositioned as a

day visitor attraction as opposed to its earlier image as a quiet location, which has been virtually destroyed by the sheer number of visitors, increased traffic, and loss of privacy. It appears that the economic benefits of *Heartbeat*'s popularity is being experienced in the neighboring towns where the day trippers are staying. Demetriadi comments on a fundamental change in the nature of the village and its relationship with visitors, which has become more resentful due to crowding and the loss of opportunities for the local community to use its own facilities. This also raises questions about the town's traditional, regular visitors who have been squeezed out. Where have they gone and how has the situation affected this relatively low-yield market?

Studying Film-Induced Tourism in Australia

The above discussion raises numerous points and issues, at the same time underlining the lack of empirical research into the impact of film on tourism. It is not always easy to preempt the popularity of a movie or TV program, which tends to make such research difficult. In Australia, a 13-part series, *Sea Change*, went to air in May 1998. The series was extremely successful for the ABC, consistently rating in the 20s, attracting up to 1,715,000 viewers across Australia's main cities, and has subsequently been sold overseas. Filming of a second series commenced in November 1998, going to air in March 1999, and the third series in 2000. Anecdotal evidence suggested that fans of the program began visiting Barwon Heads, the site of the program's fictitious Pearl Bay, to view the main sites of the show, namely the Beach House where one of the main characters, Laura, lives, and Fisherman's Wharf, Diver Dan's residence. Articles in magazines and papers have helped to promote the town as "Pearl Bay," with possibly some literary license being used to conjure up the scores of dedicated fans already making the pilgrimage, such as "Celebrating Sigrid," (Elder, 1998) where it is suspected by local traders that the author was referring to his wife as the dedicated fan he surreptitiously shadowed around Barwon Heads.

Due to the fact that the 13-week series only finished being shown in Australia in August 1998, and that this was through the winter months, it is believed that most of the impact of *Sea Change* on the town will be felt in coming months and years, par-

ticularly as the overseas popularity increases. Hence, there has been an opportunity to study the effects of a popular television series on a small town from its early stages.

Methodology

In order to ascertain the impacts of change within the family-oriented budget tourist market, a case study of the Victorian seaside village of Barwon Heads and the effect of the popular television series, *Sea Change*, is considered. While case studies have been described as speculative, unreliable, and too specific to be applied to the general, there is support in the broad discipline of the social sciences for the use of case studies, which can be extended to tourism, particularly in situations where other research methods are not possible due to physical or psychological constraints (Hall & Jenkins, 1995). Through the study of an identified case, the researcher is able to obtain place-specific conceptual insights that may then be tested for wider applicability, as well as providing the opportunity to test theoretical concepts against local and national experiences (Yin, 1994). According to Yin, a case study is "an empirical inquiry that investigates a contemporary phenomenon within its real-life context, especially when the boundaries between phenomenon and context are not clearly evident" (p. 13).

Film-induced tourism is a contemporary phenomenon that has not at this stage been adequately contextualized within academic study. Consequently, taking a research case study approach will contribute to the body of knowledge in this field.

The particular strengths of taking a case study approach lie in its grounding in reality and attention to complexity and subtlety that is difficult to identify using experimental research methods (Adelman, Jenkins, & Kemmis, 1983). In order to adequately deal with the complexity of the aim of this research, a combination of theoretical approaches has been taken in this case study, including descriptive observation, the use of media reports, and on-site survey work. Such a hybrid approach based within a case study framework is supported by Hall and Jenkins (1995), who recognize its ability to provide a richness of detail and explanatory power that is not possible with other research methods, as well as a contextual basis for tourism theory.

It is important to recognize the need for caution when utilizing case studies as they are singular instances and as such may provide misleading evidence when generalized (Pizam, 1994). However, due to the social/anthropological nature of tourism, case studies are used extensively with varying degrees of success, depending on the academic rigor applied and their original intention. Anecdotal evidence, media reports, and the researcher's experience in film-induced tourism operations suggest that the case analyzed in this article is indicative of many film-induced tourism scenarios in small holiday resorts.

It has also been argued that case studies tend to reflect the bias of the researcher; however, bias can enter into the conduct of other research strategies such as the design of questionnaires and experiments (Yin, 1994). Consequently, while the possibility of bias in any case study must be recognized and dealt with, this issue is not exclusive to this type of research. Stake (1995) maintains that recognition of researcher bias through making the reader aware of the personal experiences of gathering data and the previous experience of those involved in the work provides access to knowledge that the reader may not otherwise obtain, emphasizing that the case study is personal, situational, and intricate—a positive trait.

Case study research places particular constraints on the researcher, especially in the area of privacy and inside stories that cannot be disclosed. Consequently, the results have been provided anonymously wherever sensitive information was provided that may impact adversely on individuals within the community. While such generalization of data can evenuate in some distortion of data, awareness and recognition of such a limitation can uphold the validity of the results (Adelman et al., 1983).

The case study outlined in this article utilizes a range of research methods that include observation of visitors as well as of the physical changes in the town, informal discussions with local traders and management, a self-completion survey of visitors to the town, media reports, and other secondary data. By incorporating such a range of methods within the overall case study mode, a picture with rich information can be drawn. There has been a conscious attempt to remain unbiased; however, when using and interpreting observation and informal conversations, personal bias of the researcher may be evident. This does not detract from the significance of

the findings, but rather is an integral aspect of case study work (and of much so-called "unbiased" quantitative analysis).

Case Study: From "Barwon Heads,
Village by the Sea" to "Barwon Heads,
the Home of *Sea Change*"

Barwon Heads, a rural fishing, surfing, and holiday town south east of Geelong in Victoria, Australia, has been a popular holiday destination for Melburnians for some decades. According to the City of Greater Geelong's Economic Development Unit, the visitor accommodation base of Barwon Heads is heavily concentrated in caravan parks and holiday homes, with a capacity for 2490 overnight visitors in holiday homes, 2620 in caravan parks, and 60 in hotels, motels, and units. With a total of 6170 overnight beds available, the town has a greater overnight visitor capacity than the higher-profile resort town of Lorne with 5820 overnight beds; however, the mix is different with Lorne having 1020 beds in hotels, motels, and units, compared with Barwon Heads' 60 (City of Greater Geelong, 1999). The preponderance of holiday homes and caravan park spaces at Barwon Heads reflects the current nature of the town's overnight tourism market (including longer stays), which is predominantly families holidaying in the town regularly, usually annually. The demographics of such groups tend to fall into the lower-yield segments identified by Tourism Victoria as low priority markets.

Any increase in accommodation and commercial tourism development has the potential to dramatically change the nature and visual landscape of Barwon Heads, particularly if more motels, units, marinas, or even condominiums are built to service the high-yield visitor. A change in the type of accommodation base may also alter the visitor demographic, impacting on this significant holiday-home rental and campground markets.

Sea Change, based on a stressed-out city lawyer moving to a small seaside town to "rediscover" herself and her children, went to air on ABC TV in Australia in May 1998. The series has been consistently successful, with fans of the program visiting Barwon Heads, the site of the program's fictitious Pearl Bay, to view the main sites of the show. There has been a headlong rush in the media for informa-

tion on the area, from camping magazines such as *On the Road*, to the high-circulation (1,128,859) *Royal Auto* magazine, countless daily news articles from the local *Geelong Advertiser* to state (*The Age*) and national (*The Australian*) dailies, as well as radio and television. Such articles have not only helped to promote Barwon Heads as "Pearl Bay," but also generally support and promote the fictional on-screen image of the region. The Barwon Heads Bridge was nominated by *The Age Green Guide* staff as third in the top 20 TV spots in Victoria behind Ramsay Street (*Neighbours*) and the Pt Cook Horizon Tank as seen in *Moby Dick* ("Top 20 TV Spots in Victoria," 1999). The Internet also boasts a burgeoning number of *Sea Change* fan sites, such as the Yahoo! SC Club, Parr's SeaChange Page, and Kirsty Champion's SeaChange Page (complete with story and photographs of her *Sea Change* trip to Barwon Heads).

The site of Barwon Heads as the "home of *Sea Change*" has also been immortalized in Melbourne's major street directory, Melways, with a comment in red lettering reading, "Barwon Heads Township is the site used by the new ABC TV program *Sea Change*" (Melways, 1998, p. 233). The site of *Neighbours*, without a directory entry, still manages to attract English tourists who somehow find the location in the suburban landscape of eastern Melbourne.

Sea Change is produced and screened on ABC TV, a free-to-air, government-funded television station. Viewers of *Sea Change* tend to be women in the 40-plus age group, with Sydney and Melbourne constituting the greatest number of viewers, while male viewers constitute around half that of women in this age group. The largest group of viewers also comes from the AB quintile, which represents the highest socioeconomic group, who are typically tertiary educated, in professional occupations, and earning well above average incomes (Australian Broadcasting Commission [ABC], 2000).

In light of the evidence from other sites of the power of film to induce tourism, it can be anticipated that such viewers will undertake a pilgrimage to the sites featured in the series. If these viewers are different from existing visitors, will there be any changes to these areas to support the new visitors and will this create any conflict between the new and old visitors? Site visits confirm that a new de-

mographic is being catered for that reflects the *Sea Change* viewer profile, not only in the socioeconomic quintiles, but also in the Roy Morgan value segments that have been used extensively in tourism marketing for Victoria.

According to data collected by Roy Morgan Research, the *Sea Change* audience (as well as dominating the AB quintile) is 48% more likely than the overall population to be in the Socially Aware value segment (ABC, 2000). Visitors to the Bellarine Peninsula (in which Barwon Heads is situated) are predominantly in the Traditional Family Life value segment. These segments represents two distinct groups, with the Socially Aware segment consisting of up-market professionals in the 35–49-year age group who are social issues oriented, looking for new and different holiday experiences or the more indulgent/boutique style, such as food and wine trails. They prefer to stay in boutique four- to five-star hotels. The Traditional Family Life value segment are from the retired middle Australia segment and are family focused. Their preferred holiday experiences tend to focus on reliving the past, and they are cautious of new things. They tend to stay more in caravan parks and motels and plan their holiday experience in advance (Tourism Victoria, 1997).

If the Socially Aware value segment follow up their interest in *Sea Change* with visits to Barwon Heads, the nature of services in the community may come to reflect the interests of the group with an increase in higher level accommodation, restaurants, cafes, and other services. Such changes may or may not be welcomed by the traditional visitors from the Traditional Family Life segment and/or the local residents.

Visitors to Barwon Heads

As part of a larger study on community impacts of film-induced tourism, a survey has been undertaken to track changes in the nature of visitors to Barwon Heads from the end of the first series when the popularity was beginning to have some influence on the town, through to the heightened profile of the town gained from the immense popularity of the repeat of the first series in 1999 and the second series that followed immediately. The survey was intended to capture the traditional, regular holiday-maker as well as new overnight and day visitors. As

of January 31, 2000 a total of 171 responses had been received to a basic self-completion survey that has been distributed via retail outlets at Barwon Heads.

The two-page survey was designed to capture all visitors to the town, not just those who were aware of *Sea Change*, so there was no reference to the series until the second page. A total of 90% of respondents had heard of the series, with 94.2% of them aware that it was filmed in Barwon Heads. Of that number, 54.1% had plans to visit the sites from the series. However, when asked to nominate what sites they were visiting, the responses became more vague as not all of the sites in the series are filmed at Barwon Heads. Around 7% of visitors were hoping to see sites that are not in Barwon Heads, and 20% of the respondents nominated sites in Barwon Heads that were not actually featured in the series, indicating a potential area of conflict between image, expectations, and reality.

The majority of respondents (82%) have visited Barwon Heads previously with 89.5% of them in the past 12 months, reflecting the strength of the regular holiday market. Of those first-time visitors, 37% were prompted to come because of the *Sea Change* series. This was by far the largest motivator of this group, with the next one (usually the highest in domestic tourism), visiting friends and relatives, at 23%.

Those coming to the area purely because of *Sea Change* tended to be arriving later in the study period, particularly in the period from September 1999 to January 2000, which was after the airing of second series, reflecting the growth in popularity of the series as well as recognition of where it was filmed. In addition, the range of residential areas that the *Sea Change* visitors came from is far greater than the regular visitors, including interstate. This is providing some indicative evidence of a broadening of the visitor market due to the television series.

Changes Following *Sea Change*

The main street shopping strip has altered dramatically over the 12 months since the commencement of the *Sea Change* phenomenon. The town previously had shops vacant and closing down, in particular the green grocer, butcher, and baker. These shops have not reopened, but as of January 2000 all

shop-fronts were occupied, with the main shopping precinct now boasting a predominance of tourist services as opposed to general services. There are now 4 cafés, a bar and restaurant, a second-hand book shop, a gift shop (relocated from Point Lonsdale), an Indonesian import shop, 2 fish and chip shops, a take-away chicken shop, 2 surf shops, and an art gallery. Of these, one of the surf shops, two of the coffee shops, the gift shop, book shop, chicken shop, and bar and restaurant have all opened in the 12-month period, reflecting a shift in focus from the Traditional Family Life value segment to the Socially Aware from the retail traders. For general services such as banking, hardware supplies, and large supermarket shopping residents and visitors (particularly the self-catering budget holiday-maker) to the area are required to travel to Ocean Grove, some 5 kilometers away. There is also no police station in Barwon Heads.

Real estate values have increased significantly since the initial screening of the series, however, this may not be totally attributable to *Sea Change* per se. According to local real estate agents, the buoyant economy, recovery from a major regional investment failure with the Pyramid Building Society, and low interest rates create a favorable buying environment throughout the region (Bodey, 1999). However, it is recognized that the high prices now being seen for residences in Barwon Heads has been driven by the *Sea Change* syndrome, with cheap houses disappearing off the market (Keenan, 1999).

During the September school holidays in 1999, on one of numerous ongoing site visits, this researcher stayed in the beach house used as the main residence in the series and was continually subjected to amateur photographers snapping their own version of paradise, while other visitors ran up onto the verandah to peer through the windows. The intrusion was extreme and had resulted in a guest the previous week leaving after only one night. It was at this time that park management (the cottage is part of the Barwon Caravan Park) erected notices that read, "Visitors are requested to respect the privacy of the beach house residents." Park management expressed concern over the privacy invasions that were being experienced and suggested that they may need to eventually fence off the site, which may not only impact on public access to the foreshore walk, but also on the value of other river-frontage

sites currently occupied by campers. It was also observed that campers adjacent to the cottage were being imposed on by the increasing number of visitors wishing to view and photograph the cottage and its surrounds.

Management Plans for Barwon Heads Park— Driven by *Sea Change*?

The Barwon Heads Park and camping ground is the site for the most recognizable aspects of *Sea Change* (apart from some filming at St Leonards and Williamstown), namely the residences of the main romantic leads, now known as Laura's Beach House and either the Coolstores or Diver Dan's. Also, the images of fishing boats, the bridge (which is central to the narrative), and the tidal views feature significantly in the series, providing a visual backdrop to much of the action. The light and alterations due to the tidal flows in the area provide some of the most beautiful images in the series. These are also among the main attractions for campers and other recreational visitors to the park.

Plans developed for the management of the park include a series of actions that have been interpreted by some as precursors to privatizing the publicly owned and managed caravan park. Proposed "priority actions" for the caravan park include comprehensive upgrades of the camping sites, adding four fully serviced cabins next to Laura's Beach House, and relocating the football club (traditionally based at the oval in the caravan park). Off-site developments that are adjacent to the caravan park (managed by the same management committee) include the development of the Fisherman's Jetty restaurant, completion of a new boatshed facility incorporating an interpretation center and picnic facilities, and the creation of a conservation and education-based walk (Barwon Coast Committee of Management, 1999).

Due to fears of privatization and loss of public amenity and access, there has been a strong reaction to some of the proposals from both locals and traditional caravan park visitors. These fears had been largely based on the release of information in April 1999 that the then Liberal state government was considering leasing or selling 173 caravan parks currently on Crown land, "... putting at risk the tradition of a cheap camping holiday" (McKay, 1999, p. 6). The Barwon Heads caravan park itself fea-

tured in a number of articles on the plan (for example, Batt, 1999). Since the commencement of the privatization debate there has been a change of government, which may lead to a change in policy as when they were in Opposition, the state Labour Party opposed such a course of action.

How much has this to do with *Sea Change*? Many of the actions outlined in the proposed management plans have been under discussion for many years, but increased demand from new visitors and the associated promise of economic gain from the success of *Sea Change* is extremely timely and may provide the impetus for the implementation and eventual success of the developments, particularly those involved with the jetty and Laura's beach house precinct. Each side of the debate has appropriated the *Sea Change* effect to support their stance, with opponents to the restaurant development claiming that the sheds and jetty provide "an environmentally sound, sustainable and growing attraction for visitors. ..." while claiming that "in Britain, governments are ... protecting the charming local sights of TV series. ..." (Oberin/Trayling & Flick, 1999). On the other hand, supporters of the development claim that it is needed and that "*Sea Change* has certainly livened up Barwon Heads ... a couple of local young men were enterprising enough to set up a make-shift outdoor café, near ... Diver Dan's ... The café, was so successful, the young men ... are about to convert the Fisherman's co-op into a restaurant" (Ryllis Clark, 1999, p.4). In actual fact, the restaurant development did not result from the popularity of the series; instead, the park management had decided to develop a restaurant on the site some years previously, but by the time the contract was granted to the restaurateurs filming of the series was underway at the site. Consequently, they could not develop the site immediately, so they opened a small café that operated until filming of the second series was completed. The "story" had been altered to support a particular perspective.

In a stunning role-reversal the ABC itself appropriated the controversy to promote the series through a report on its television current affairs program, *The 7.30 Report*, where the anchor, Maxine McKew, introduced the report stating that "... some ambitious locals want to develop a \$500,000 restaurant on the site where Diver Dan dallied with Laura Gibson" (Australian Broadcasting Commission, 1999). The

report was heavily peppered with references to the series and inferences of some real-life connection between the fictional characters of Pearl Bay and those living in Barwon Heads, with cuts to selected clips of the series featuring the real estate agent, Bob Jelly, interspersed with comment from the real-life Barwon Heads agent, Rodger Bodey. Informal discussions with some of those interviewed revealed a high level of dissatisfaction with the selective nature of the report.

Conclusion

While tourism bodies remain focused on the high-yielding sectors of the tourism industry, disenfranchisement of the budget holiday-maker is a real issue, and may finally be financially counter-productive for many even well established tourist sites. Until the prevailing economic-rationalist attitude is tempered with a recognition of the value of intangible aspects that make up the quality of life, such a focus will remain with potentially dangerous results. The need for recreation and relaxation is recognized as central to a healthy, happy, productive life, but while the tourism industry is preoccupied with allegedly high-yield market segments, the health of the Australian community is compromised.

In addition, the underlying issues in this case study are internationally significant, providing a revelatory case for the application of the concepts and concerns outlined to other tourism destinations. This can assist communities in planning optimum levels of development, visitor numbers, and yield they desire and/or require in conjunction with film-induced tourism. It may also be utilized in regional tourism policy development where external factors affecting yield, development, and visitor numbers are introduced through the policy decisions in other domains. For example, agricultural policy decisions may affect visitor numbers to a rural region, or other recreational policies may affect the level of development or yield.

References

- Adelman, C., Jenkins, D., & Kemmis, S. (1983). Rethinking case study: Notes from the second Cambridge conference. *Case study methods I* (2nd ed., pp. 1-10). Warrn Ponds: Deakin University.
- Australian Broadcasting Commission. (1999, July 21). Tourists and developers seek out their own Pearl Bay. *7.30 Report*.
- Australian Broadcasting Commission. (2000, February). *Sea Change, Summary of Audiences*. Report prepared by ABC Audience Research [unpublished].
- Barwon Coast Committee of Management. (1999). *Proposed management and business plans*. Barwon Heads.
- Batt, C. (1999, April 6). Happy campers for the past 30 years. *The Age*, p. 6.
- Beeton, S. (1998). *Horseback tourism in Victoria*. Masters thesis, Monash University.
- Bodey, R. (1999). *Bodey's summer report 1998/9*. Barwon Heads: Bodey Real Estate.
- Bushell, R. (1999). Hollywood movie damages Thailand National Park [unpublished email correspondence].
- Butler, R. W. (1980). The concept of a tourism area cycle of evolution: Implications for management of resources. *Canadian Geographer*, 24, 5-12.
- City of Greater Geelong. (1999). *Geelong economic indicators bulletin 1997/8*.
- Demetriadi, J. (1996, October/November). The tele tourists. *Hospitality*, 14-15.
- Department of Natural Resources and Environment. (1996). Permit issuance for season of 1996 [unpublished].
- Edgington, D. (1996). The Iowa Passage. *Des Moines Business Record*, 92(22), p. 16.
- Elder, J. (1998, December 25). Celebrating Sigrid. *The Age*, p. 9.
- Friends of the Lake District. (1996, Autumn). The Darcy Effect. *Friends of the Lake District Report and Newsletter*, 41-42.
- Hall, C. M. (1995). *Introduction to tourism in Australia* (2nd ed.). Melbourne: Longman.
- Hall, C. M., & Jenkins, J. (1995). *Tourism and public policy*. London: Routledge.
- African village says it did not profit from Alex Haley's "Roots." (1995, April 10). *Jet*, 87(22), 26-27.
- Keenan, A. (1999, October 3). Driving for pearls: Melbourne heads to Barwon for a change. *The Sunday Age Property*, pp. 1-2.
- KPMG Management Consulting. (1997). *Bays & peninsulas: Regional tourism development plan*. Melbourne: Tourism Victoria.
- Lures and enticements. (1998, March 14). *Economist*, 346(8059), 28-29.
- McKay, S. (1999, April 6). Come clean on caravan park plan, ALP urges. *The Age*, p. 6.
- Melways. (1998). *Greater Melbourne street directory* (map 233). Glen Iris: Melway Publishing.
- Neale, S. (1994). Tom Kershaw: Everybody knows his name. *Boston Business Journal*, 14(22), p. 18.
- Oberin/Trayling, G., & Flick, B. (1999, August 4). Bigger picture. *The Echo, Letters*, p. 13.
- O'Regan, T. (1988). "Fair Dinkum Fillums": The Crocodile Dundee phenomenon. In E. Jacka & S. Dermody (Eds.), *The imaginary industry: Australian film in the late '80s* (pp. 155-175). Sydney: Australian Film Television and Radio School and Media Information Australia.

- Pizam, A. (1994). Planning a tourism research investigation. In J. R. B. Ritchie & C. R. Goeldner (Eds.), *Travel, tourism and hospitality research, a handbook for managers and researchers* (2nd ed., pp. 91-104). New York: John Wiley & Sons.
- Riley, R., Baker, D., & Van Doren, C. S. (1998). Movie induced tourism. *Annals of Tourism Research*, 25(4), 919-935.
- Rob Roy to the rescue. (1995, May 13). *Economist*, 335(7914), 57.
- Ryllis Clark, M. (1999, June 13). Lou Stinson's Barwon Heads. *The Sunday Age, Escape Section*, p. 4.
- Schofield, P. (1996). Cinematographic images of a city, alternative heritage tourism in Manchester. *Tourism Management*, 17(5), 333-340.
- Stake, R. E. (1995). *The art of case study research*. Thousand Oaks: Sage Publications.
- Top 20 TV spots in Victoria. (1999, January 28). *The Age Green Guide*, p. 2.
- Tooke, N., & Baker, M. (1996). Seeing is believing: The effect of film on visitor numbers to screened locations. *Tourism Management*, 17(2), 87-94.
- Tourism Victoria. (1993). *Strategic business plan, 1993*. Melbourne: Author.
- Tourism Victoria. (1997). *Strategic business plan, 1997-2001, building partnerships*. Melbourne: Author.
- Yin, R. K. (1994). *Case study research. Design and methods* (2nd ed.). Beverly Hills, CA: Sage Publications.